

LAKSH'S DAILY BRIEF

Laksh's Daily Brief — August 3, 2026

Monday, August 3, 2026

World · Markets & Money · AI & Infrastructure · Models & Research



[inkl.com](#) — The week that was in international affairs: Saudi...



[en.apa.az](#) — Podolyak: Zelenskyy proposes airspace ceasefire and freezing of frontline to Putin



[outlookbusiness.com](#) — India Plans ₹450 Billion Rail Push Along Pakistan, China Borders to Boost Military Mobility

1. World & Geopolitics

Trump insists Iran talks are underway despite Tehran's denials as strikes continue. The U.S. president claimed on Truth Social that peace negotiations are happening "whether Iran wants to admit it or not," after Iran's foreign ministry said talks were only with Oman, not the U.S. ([CNBC](#)). The back-and-forth follows Trump's pattern of announcing halts to strikes that then keep happening ([PBS](#)). Meanwhile, Kuwait said it responded to new Iranian drone attacks, and a tanker was struck in the **Strait of Hormuz** — the chokepoint for about 20% of global oil transit ([PBS](#)). Iranians feel whipsawed by Trump's on-again, off-again conflict posture ([Al Jazeera](#)).

Israeli strikes kill 15 in Gaza despite Trump's "breakthrough" announcement. Israeli airstrikes continued for a second straight day, killing at least four Palestinians on Sunday, after Trump claimed progress on implementing last year's ceasefire ([Reuters](#)). Hamas had agreed to a disarmament deal, but Israel said a weapons depot was found at a hospital site. A new illegal Israeli outpost was also spotted in the occupied West Bank ([Al Jazeera](#)).

Zelenskyy proposes an airspace ceasefire and freezing the frontline, but Putin flatly rejects negotiations. Ukraine's president called for a total ceasefire, an all-for-all prisoner exchange, and peace talks — a proposal Russia has repeatedly declined ([apa.az](#)). *Foreign Affairs* analysts say Putin sees no point in negotiating, intending to continue military operations despite Ukrainian strikes on Russian

infrastructure ([UA.NEWS](#)). Both sides hope the war ends before winter, but trust remains at rock bottom ([The Statesman](#)).

India plans a ₹450 billion rail push along its borders with Pakistan and China. The railway expansion is meant to boost military mobility and serve civilian logistics, reflecting New Delhi's strategy to harden infrastructure in contested regions ([Outlook Business](#)). The Nathu La Pass with China was recently reopened, signaling a modest thaw after the 2020 Galwan clash ([The Hawk](#)). India also eased FDI rules for Chinese investors up to 10% earlier this year ([The Geopolitics](#)).

Bangladesh's reported deal for Chinese J-10CE fighter jets alarms India. The purchase would embed Bangladesh's air force in China's defense-industrial ecosystem, adding to India's concerns about Chinese military encirclement ([Defence Security Asia](#)). Bangladesh has become a critical arena of geopolitical competition between China, India, and Pakistan ([Rediff](#)).

China moves to lock in a new edge on Taiwan before the next Trump-Xi summit. Military pressure in the Taiwan Strait remained stable in the first half of 2026, but China is using diplomatic channels to consolidate its position ahead of another summit ([The Diplomat](#)). The "One China" policy remains a gambit of strategic ambiguity, with increasing Chinese military assertiveness ([Taiwan Insight](#)). Global Times warns that Washington must truly curb "Taiwan independence" to avoid conflict ([Global Times](#)).

Senate GOP rushes to pass a budget bill, avoid shutdown ahead of midterms. The Washington Post reports that Republicans are scrambling to fund the government before the deadline, with midterm election pressures looming ([Washington Post](#)).

Manufacturing survey shows inflation worries "worse than pandemic era." The latest ISM data reveals purchasing managers struggling with price volatility, adding pressure on the Fed to hold rates higher for longer ([CNBC](#)).

2. Markets, Money & Deals

Federal Reserve held rates at 3.50%-3.75% in July, with no forward guidance. The decision was widely expected, but Fed Chair Kevin Warsh shelved forward-looking guidance from the FOMC statement for the first time in a decade, making it harder for markets to predict the next move ([The Globe and Mail](#)). The CME FedWatch tool shows a 70.6% probability of another hold at the next meeting ([Benzinga](#)). Warsh also floated the idea of fewer Fed meetings to reduce market dependence on rate decisions ([WBFF](#)). The 10-year Treasury yield was at 4.61%, the 2-year at 4.30% — a persistently inverted **yield curve** (short-term rates above long-term rates), which historically signals recession risk.

Deal roundup: - **KKR to buy Integer Holdings** for \$5.7 billion, taking the medical device maker private ([Reuters](#)). - **Grant Thornton agrees to acquire CBIZ** for \$5 billion, creating the fifth-largest U.S. accounting firm. CBIZ shares jumped 17% on the news ([Invezz](#)). The deal includes a "go-shop" period through August 27 ([Economic Times](#)). - **Visa (V) to buy cybersecurity firm BioCatch** for \$2.4 billion, expanding its value-added services business amid a surge in AI-powered scams ([CNBC](#)). - **Valar Atomic**s, a nuclear startup, raised \$1 billion at a \$6 billion valuation led by Sequoia's Shaun

Maguire, after signing a development deal with Nvidia in June ([TechCrunch](#)). - **AstraZeneca investors** are balking at a potential \$400 billion acquisition of Bristol Myers Squibb, according to Reuters ([Reuters](#)). - **WSP Global's \$5.7 billion bid for Arcadis** was rejected by the Dutch engineering firm ([Reuters](#)).

Imax (IMAX) stock hit an all-time high as Christopher Nolan's "The Odyssey" continues to drive box office receipts. CEO called the momentum a "flywheel" ([CNBC](#)). Shares were up 5.37% in the snapshot.

SpaceX stock is down nearly 50% from its high. MarketWatch warns it's not a bargain yet, as a wave of shares will become available for sale ([MarketWatch](#)).

AMD (AMD) heads into earnings with two engines roaring: robust server demand and the upcoming ramp of its new rack-scale offering, analysts say ([MarketWatch](#)). AMD shares were up 1.98% in the snapshot.

Crypto & fintech: Robinhood (HOOD) was up 6.12%, Coinbase (COIN) up 3.71%, and SoFi (SOFI) jumped 9.56% — continuing a rally in fintech stocks, though no specific catalyst was cited in the sources.

3. AI & Infrastructure

Google goes cash flow negative for the first time as AI capex doubles to \$44.9 billion in a single quarter. Alphabet's Q2 net income of \$112.1 billion overstates the picture because the company's AI data center buildout is consuming vast amounts of cash ([Tom's Hardware](#)). The four largest hyperscalers plan a combined 2026 capex of ~\$725 billion, up 77% on 2025. Meta raised its 2026 forecast to \$125-\$145 billion. This is a classic tension: **capital expenditure (capex)** — the money spent on physical assets like data centers — is soaring, but **operating cash flow minus capex = free**

cash flow (FCF) is shrinking for some. Investors are starting to doubt whether the spending will pay off ([Fierce Network](#)).

Microsoft is openly competing with OpenAI and Anthropic more than ever. CEO Satya Nadella is not letting the trajectory of the two AI labs — in which Microsoft holds stakes — expand into applications and agentic infrastructure without a fight. Barclays estimates OpenAI and Anthropic account for 13% of Microsoft's cloud revenue this year and 18% next year ([TechCrunch](#)). Two-thirds of the year-over-year growth in

Microsoft's Intelligent Cloud segment comes from those two customers ([ppc.land](#)). Microsoft proved AI spending can pay off, says the Motley Fool, but the hyperscaler capex wall is causing investor anxiety ([The Motley Fool](#)).

Nvidia (NVDA) remains at the center of the AI trade.

The company generated nearly \$50 billion in free cash flow in a single quarter, which buys forgiveness on multiple compression. The 24/7 Wall St. price target of \$262.81 remains a buy at high confidence, but caution is warranted if hyperscaler capex guides roll over into 2027 ([247wallst](#)). Nvidia guided Q2 to \$91 billion, excluding China data center compute, and the ACIE (AI, Cloud, Infrastructure, Enterprise) and sovereign AI cohort may offset the China gap ([247wallst](#)). Nvidia shares were up 3.52% in the snapshot.

Open Secure AI Alliance launched, but OpenAI, Google, and Anthropic are absent. The Nvidia-led coalition of over 30 companies (including Microsoft, SpaceX, The Linux Foundation, Adobe, Siemens) aims to build open-source tools for AI security. The

conspicuous absence of the top frontier labs suggests a divide between infrastructure providers and model developers ([Tom's Hardware](#)).

EU AI Act transparency rules came into effect on August 2. Companies must now disclose when people are interacting with AI models and label AI-generated content, including deepfakes ([The Verge](#)). The White House will also host AI companies Tuesday to review a new model-testing framework ([CNBC](#)).

Base Power raised another \$1 billion to deploy backyard batteries for grid resilience. The startup's home batteries aim to stabilize the grid as AI data center demand pushes electricity consumption to new highs ([TechCrunch](#)).

Nvidia RTX 50 series prices jump up to 30% in South Korea, driven by TSMC wafer price hikes and expensive GDDR7 memory modules. The RTX 5090 now exceeds \$5,100 ([Tom's Hardware](#)).

4. Model & Research Watch

Alibaba released Qwen3.8-Max, a 2.4 trillion-parameter open-weight model with a 1 million-token context window. The model challenges GPT-5.6 Sol and Claude Fable 5 on benchmarks ([Neowin](#)). It is designed for long-horizon AI tasks and is available as open-source, lowering costs for global developers ([The Decoder](#)). The model's release is part of a wave of Chinese open-weight models that Hugging Face CEO says could catch up to the U.S. as soon as this year ([CNBC](#)).

Moonshot AI's Kimi K3 (2.8 trillion parameters, 1 million-token context) was released as open weights on July 27. It scored 57 on the Artificial Analysis Intelligence Index, placing fourth behind Claude Fable 5 (~60) and two GPT-5.6 Sol variants, and ahead of Claude Opus 4.8 (~56). The model uses a **Mixture-of-Experts (MoE)** architecture with 896 experts, activating 16 per token, which makes it 2-3x easier to run than dense models of similar size ([Tom's Hardware](#)). Moonshot also closed a \$3.5 billion funding round, but concerns about China data risks remain ([Tech Times](#)). Kimi K3's technical report details architectural innovations: Kimi Delta Attention, Stable LatentMoE, and

Attention Residuals that retrieve information from earlier network depths ([Substack](#)).

OpenAI introduced "Astra," claiming it solved 10 longstanding mathematical problems. The breakthrough reignited debate about AI's future, with Elon Musk and Sam Altman renewing claims about the path to AGI ([Google News](#)). No concrete benchmark details were provided in the sources.

OpenAI and Anthropic are effectively writing the safety threshold their rivals must clear for launch. Despite competing fiercely, the two labs are collaborating on setting evaluation standards that new models must pass before release — a rare example of pre-competitive cooperation in frontier AI ([Tech Times](#)).

Zhipu AI is reportedly working on a trillion-parameter GLM-5.5 model, but the company remains silent on details ([Startup Fortune](#)).

Science & Frontier Tech: - AI helps astronomers discover a wandering black hole 30,000 light-years from a galaxy's center, after it passed in front of a background star ([Moneycontrol](#)). - NASA's Curiosity rover discovered unusual "honeycomb" patterns on

Mars, deepening the mystery of the Red Planet's geological history ([The Debrief](#)).

5. Watchlist: Earnings, Guidance & Movers

No notable earnings reports for watchlist companies in the last 24 hours from the sources. The approximate

quote snapshot shows the following moves (vs. prior close):

Company (Ticker)	Price	Change
Coherent (COHR)	\$290.74	+10.60%
Applied Optoelectronics (AAOI)	\$108.28	+14.80%
Lumentum (LITE)	\$774.97	+8.55%
Redwire (RDW)	\$9.62	+11.60%
SoFi (SOFI)	\$17.87	+9.56%
SanDisk (SNDK)	\$1,298.27	+6.87%
Rigetti Computing (RGTI)	\$16.20	+8.39%
Meta (META)	\$591.06	+6.17%
Robinhood (HOOD)	\$91.86	+6.12%
Alphabet (GOOGL)	\$374.65	+5.20%
Microsoft (MSFT)	\$488.88	+5.20%
Amazon (AMZN)	\$284.21	+4.65%
Vistra (VST)	\$155.11	+4.67%
Credo (CRDO)	\$216.07	+4.39%
Constellation Energy (CEG)	\$273.67	+4.16%
Nvidia (NVDA)	\$207.81	+3.52%
Tesla (TSLA)	\$322.70	+3.69%
Coinbase (COIN)	\$151.69	+3.71%
Astera Labs (ALAB)	\$323.14	+3.83%
Imax (IMAX)	\$50.41	+5.37% (all-time high per CNBC)

The broad rally in AI-exposed names (COHR, AAOI, LITE, NVDA, CRDO, ALAB) reflects continued optimism about the AI infrastructure buildout. The sources do not provide specific catalysts for individual moves beyond the general themes of hyperscaler capex, open-weight model releases driving inference demand, and the Imax "Odyssey" story.

SpaceX (SPCX) — stock down nearly 50% from its high; MarketWatch warns it's not a bargain ([MarketWatch](#)).

Intel (INTC) — shares up 0.50%; no notable news in the sources. **AMD (AMD)** up 1.98% ahead of earnings. **Broadcom (AVGO)** flat (-0.03%). **KLA Corp (KLAC)** down 1.62%.

6. How It Connects (Infrastructure & Supply-Chain Logic)

Chain 1: Open-weight model explosion → inference demand → GPU/accelerator sales → networking/

optics → power/cooling. The release of Kimi K3 (2.8T params, MoE, 1M context) and Qwen3.8-Max (2.4T

params, 1M context) means more developers will run frontier-level models locally and in production. Open-weight models require significant compute for inference, not just training. This drives demand for Nvidia's H20 and Blackwell GPUs, AMD's MI series, and the networking (Coherent, Lumentum, Credo, Marvell) and optics (Applied Optoelectronics) needed to connect them. Running these models at scale also requires massive power — benefiting Vistra (VST), Constellation Energy (CEG), and nuclear startups like Valar Atomics (which just raised \$1B with a Nvidia partnership). The Base Power \$1B round for home batteries fits the same grid-resilience theme.

Chain 2: Hyperscaler capex surge → cash flow strain → investor scrutiny → but AI revenue growth justifies it. Google went cash flow negative as capex doubled to \$44.9B in a quarter. The four hyperscalers plan \$725B in combined 2026 capex. This creates a tension: **operating cash flow minus capex = free cash flow (FCF)** is shrinking for some, raising the question of whether the spending will pay off. However, Microsoft's

AI revenue is growing fast — OpenAI and Anthropic alone account for 13% of Microsoft's cloud revenue. Nvidia's FCF of ~\$50B/quarter shows the money is flowing back to the GPU suppliers. The risk is that if hyperscaler capex guides roll over in 2027, the entire AI supply chain could face a correction.

Chain 3: Iran/Gulf tensions → Strait of Hormuz risk → oil prices → inflation → Fed policy → bond yields → equity valuations. The ongoing strikes and counter-strikes involving Iran, the U.S., Israel, and Gulf states keep the Strait of Hormuz chokepoint in focus. A disruption could spike oil prices, feeding into the manufacturing inflation worries that the ISM survey flagged as "worse than pandemic era." That would pressure the Fed to hold rates higher for longer — or even hike — which would compress valuations for tech stocks and growth companies. The yield curve is already inverted (2-year at 4.30% vs 10-year at 4.61%), a classic recession signal that the Fed's no-forward-guidance stance makes harder to interpret.

7. Building Your Knowledge

- **When the Fed removes forward guidance, markets become more volatile.** The FOMC statement is the main tool for shaping expectations. By removing the forward-looking language, Chair Warsh forced investors to rely on the FedWatch tool and economic data releases. This is a lesson in how central bank communication is itself a policy instrument — removing it is a tightening of uncertainty, even if rates stay unchanged.
- **Open-weight models are a double-edged sword for the AI supply chain.** They lower the cost of running AI (good for adoption) but also reduce the moat of proprietary model providers like OpenAI and Anthropic. However, more inference demand still benefits the hardware layer — Nvidia, AMD, Broadcom, and networking companies — because you need compute to run any model, regardless of who built it.
- **The yield curve inversion (short-term rates above long-term rates) has historically predicted every U.S. recession since the 1970s.** The current inversion (2-year at 4.30% vs 10-year at 4.61%) has been in place for over a year. The typical lag is 6-24 months. The Fed's hold at 3.50-3.75% reflects the dilemma: inflation is still sticky (manufacturing survey shows "worse than pandemic" price pressures), but the economy shows signs of slowing.
- **Capex vs. opex is a fundamental distinction in analyzing any company. Capital expenditure (capex)** is money spent on long-term assets (data centers, GPU clusters, factories). **Operating expense (opex)** is day-to-day spending (salaries, electricity, cloud services). When Google's capex doubled, its operating cash flow couldn't cover it, making **free cash flow negative** — a red flag that investors watch closely. The key question is whether the capex will generate enough future revenue to justify the current cash burn.
- **Geopolitical risk in the Strait of Hormuz is not just about oil — it's about the global semiconductor supply chain.** Every smartphone, computer, and AI system depends on Taiwan for advanced chips. The Taiwan Strait is a similar chokepoint. The U.S.-China tensions over Taiwan are the single biggest geopolitical risk for the entire AI infrastructure thesis,

as a blockade would halt TSMC's output, disrupting Nvidia, Apple, AMD, and nearly every tech company.

- **The EU AI Act transparency rules are a regulatory milestone that will shape global norms.** The requirement to label AI-generated content and

disclose when you're interacting with a bot is likely to be copied by other jurisdictions. This creates compliance costs for companies like Meta, Google, and OpenAI, but also builds consumer trust — which could accelerate enterprise adoption.

8. Terms & Concepts

Concept Spotlight: Yield Curve

What it is: The yield curve is a graph plotting the interest rates of bonds with different maturities, from short-term (3 months, 2 years) to long-term (10 years, 30 years). Normally, long-term bonds pay higher yields because investors demand compensation for locking up money longer (the "term premium"). An **inverted yield curve** — when short-term rates are higher than long-term rates — is a rare and historically reliable recession signal.

Concrete example: As of August 3, 2026, the 2-year U.S. Treasury yields 4.30%, while the 10-year yields 4.61%. That's a *positive* slope (normal). But earlier in the cycle, the 2-year was above the 10-year, creating an inversion. The curve is now "steepening" but still relatively flat by historical standards.

Real use case for investors: When the yield curve inverts, it signals that markets expect the Fed to cut rates in the future (because the economy will weaken). That's why short-term rates are high (Fed fighting inflation) but long-term rates are lower (expecting recession). Investors use the spread between 2-year and 10-year yields as a key indicator. A sustained inversion has preceded every U.S. recession since the 1970s.

Rough numbers/benchmarks: - Normal curve: 2-year ~3%, 10-year ~5% (spread of +2%) - Inverted curve: 2-year ~5%, 10-year ~4% (spread of -1%) - Current: 2-year 4.30%, 10-year 4.61% (spread +0.31% — barely positive, but recently inverted)

Caution/common misconception: The yield curve inversion doesn't predict the *timing* of a recession — it can stay inverted for 1-2 years before a downturn hits. Also, the curve can "un-invert" (steepen) as the economy actually enters recession, because the Fed

starts cutting short-term rates. So an inversion is a warning, not a trigger.

Other Terms

- **Forward Guidance:** Communication from a central bank about its intended future policy path. The Fed's July 2026 statement omitted forward guidance for the first time in a decade, making rate decisions harder to predict and increasing market volatility.
- **Free Cash Flow (FCF):** Operating cash flow minus capital expenditure. It measures the cash a company has left after maintaining its asset base. Google went FCF-negative in Q2 2026 because its AI data center capex (\$44.9B) exceeded operating cash flow. Investors watch FCF because it funds dividends, buybacks, and debt repayment.
- **Sovereign AI:** The concept of nations building their own AI capabilities (compute infrastructure, models, data) to avoid dependence on a few U.S. or Chinese companies. Nvidia's "sovereign AI" business is a growing revenue stream, as countries buy GPU clusters for national AI initiatives.
- **Open-weights model:** An AI model whose trained parameters (weights) are released publicly, allowing anyone to download, run, fine-tune, and audit it. Kimi K3 and Qwen3.8-Max are open-weight models. This is different from "open-source" (which also includes training code, data, and methodology). Open-weight models lower barriers to entry but can't be fully reproduced without the training recipe.
- **Agent Benchmarks:** Standardized tests to evaluate how well AI agents (systems that can take actions, browse the web, use tools) perform on real-world tasks. The new OpenClaw and Ollama paper discusses frameworks for evaluating autonomous agents. This is a rapidly evolving field — agent benchmarks are less mature than language model benchmarks.

- **Token efficiency:** A measure of how many tokens (words/pieces of text) a model needs to process a given input. More efficient models use fewer tokens for the same task, reducing compute cost and latency.

Kimi K3's MoE architecture achieves high token efficiency by activating only 16 of 896 experts per token.

9. Bottom Line

Today's brief is dominated by **continued geopolitical volatility** (Iran on-off strikes, Gaza violence, Ukraine stalemate) and **an accelerating open-weights model war** between U.S. and Chinese labs. The Fed's hold with no forward guidance has injected uncertainty into rate expectations, while hyperscaler capex is straining balance sheets even as AI revenue grows. The biggest new element is the wave of Chinese open-weight models (Kimi K3, Qwen3.8-Max, Hugging Face CEO's warning) — this shifts the competitive dynamics: if frontier-level models become freely available, the moat shifts from the model itself to the hardware, the data, and the distribution.

What changed since the previous brief: - **Iran situation:** Trump now insists talks are underway, but Iran denies, and strikes continue. The pattern of "calling off strikes" that still happen adds to the uncertainty. No de-escalation yet. - **Gaza:** Israeli strikes killed 15 despite Trump's "breakthrough" — the ceasefire remains fragile. - **Fed:** Held rates at 3.50-3.75%, removed forward guidance for the first time in a decade, and Warsh floated fewer meetings. This is a significant shift in

communication strategy. - **Google went cash flow negative** for the first time, as AI capex doubled to \$44.9B. This is a warning signal for the hyperscaler capex narrative. - **Alibaba's Qwen3.8-Max** (2.4T params, 1M context, open-weight) was released, joining the open-weights race. The Hugging Face CEO said China could catch up this year. - **Imax hit an all-time high** on "The Odyssey" — a reminder that entertainment and AI are separate demand drivers. - **Valar Atomic**s (nuclear startup) raised \$1B with Nvidia's backing — a concrete sign of the energy-buildout theme. - **SpaceX stock down 50% from high** — a cautionary tale about private market valuations.

The big picture: **The AI infrastructure buildout is still accelerating, but the financial and geopolitical risks are mounting.** The open-weights wave could be the most disruptive development of the year — it democratizes access but also introduces new security and control risks. The Strait of Hormuz and Taiwan Strait remain the two chokepoints that could derail the entire thesis.

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